Glory be ever Glorious'. This idea would be reinforced in Abu'l Fazl's *Akbarnama*, in which he would project Akbar as the Insaan-e Adil (Perfect Man) and kingship itself as emanating from a Farr-i Izadi (Divine Light). But for Akbar the essence of sulh kul was an eclectic collection of rather non-heretical thoughts. Ten virtues were encouraged (liberality, forbearance from bad actions and controlling of anger with gentleness, abstinence, freedom from excessive materialism, piety, devotion, prudence, kindness, attachment to God) of which nine were taken directly from the Koran. The recommendations for disciples were more in the manner of moral guidelines and bodily practices, such as giving up meat on certain days. As for the disciples, only eighteen were ever accounted for, making this more a collection of like-minded courtiers who were willing to go along with the Padshah on his religious quest rather than a new religion for everyone as has been suggested. They included Shaikh Mubarak and his sons, Abd al-Samad the painter and his son, Muhammad Sharif, and Raja Birbal.* These members owed a four-fold allegiance to Akbar, the Ikhlas-i-Chahargana, which was defined by a willingness to sacrifice lives, property, honour, and religion. Of the eighteen disciples only one, Raja Birbal, was a Hindu.

The very small number of murids who actually followed this formulation of the Padshah demonstrates the resistance to these eclectic ideas even among the great amirs of the court. Shahbaz Khan Kamboh was an orthodox, devout Sunni, a prickly man, and a competent officer. At Fatehpur Sikri, he refused to shave his beard as was the custom among Akbar's courtiers, nor did he agree to become a disciple of Akbar. On one occasion, the Padshah was conversing with him one-on-one at the time of the midday namaaz. Hakim Abu'l Fath, watching from a distance, nudged Hakim Ali, and wondered aloud if Shahbaz Khan would be able to perform the namaaz, which was discouraged by Akbar. But while the Padshah tried to remonstrate with his courtier, Shahbaz Khan hastily laid down his dupatta and knelt to perform his prayers, while Akbar smacked him on the head the whole time, asking him to stand up.

When a few years later in 1587 Akbar brought up the subject of discipleship with another favourite courtier, Kuar Man Singh, the Kuar was unequivocal and replied with candour: 'If discipleship means willingness to sacrifice one's life, I have already carried my life in my hand, what need is there of further proof? If, however, the term has another meaning and refers to faith, I certainly am a Hindu. If you order me to do so, I will become a